

It doesn't have to be that way. The truth is, a successful marriage is like a pizza pie, and love is only one slice. You can argue that love is an important slice, and I won't disagree with you. But there are other slices, too, slices nobody wants to talk about in our rom-com-saturated world. If you know anything about me, it probably won't surprise you to hear me stress the importance of money above romance.

I'm not saying you should marry a millionaire. When my mother married George, his life savings fit easily into his pocket. He went to the notary's office with my two uncles to obtain a marriage contract, and when the notary asked him about his liquid assets, he answered honestly, "I've got 36 to my name."

"Thirty-six thousand?" the notary asked. "That's great!"

"No," George answered. "Thirty-six *dollars*."

You might think my mother was crazy, getting hitched to a man with so little to his name. She wasn't. George was a smart investment. A year after they married, he completed his PhD in business from the University of Illinois and obtained a plum position as an advisor and consultant with a United Nations agency. I benefited from a multicultural upbringing because of George's appointments in countries as far-flung as Cambodia, Cyprus, Ethiopia and Tunisia.

Of course, no one has a crystal ball, including my mother. Georgette had no way of knowing with 100 percent certainty that George would turn out to be a smart investment. But she did do some things differently to create financial security for herself and her sons.

First, she did *relationship due diligence*. George and Georgette dated for more than three years before they got married. They had plenty of time to get to know one another and to suss out core compatibilities as well as identify any potential roadblocks. And second, *she went into the relationship with her own money*.

As co-owner of the family clothing business in Montreal, my mother had her own funds. She met George during a brief holiday abroad. Their first date was nothing extravagant: they went dancing with friends and collected seashells in my mother's oversized straw